

The Florida Senior Year *Roadmap*

Every deadline, form and step for senior year, month by month, so nothing slips through the cracks. Made for Florida families.

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Senior year *at a glance*

Five things decide how smoothly senior year goes. Everything else in this roadmap supports these.

1. Know every deadline

Early deadlines at Florida universities start **October 15**. Write each school's dates in the tracker (page 8) the first week of school.

2. File two aid forms

The **FAFSA** (federal aid) and the **FFAA** (Florida's form for Bright Futures and state aid). They are separate. You need both.

3. Lock in Bright Futures

GPA, test score, service or work hours, then the FFAA. Ask the counselor for a Bright Futures evaluation in the fall.

4. Ask early, follow up

Check which schools want recommendation letters (UF and UCF don't use them). If needed, ask teachers **3–4 weeks** ahead. Check every portal weekly.

5. Compare real costs before May 1

Acceptance letters arrive first, then aid offers. Compare what you'd actually pay at each school (page 10) before paying a deposit. UF, FSU, FIU and FAU list **May 1** as the deposit deadline for Early Action and regular admits. Early Decision deposits are due much sooner.

✓ This month's quick wins

- ☐ Make a list of every school your student is applying to, with the plan for each (Early Decision, Early Action or regular)
- ☐ Create StudentAid.gov accounts for your student and each parent who must be a FAFSA contributor (usually one)
- ☐ Find the school counselor's email and ask for a Bright Futures evaluation
- ☐ Put one 20-minute "college check-in" on the family calendar every week this fall

How to use this roadmap: Read it once now. Then each month, open the month-by-month checklist (pages 4–5), check things off, and update the trackers. Use pencil, because dates and plans change.

Key dates for *Florida seniors*

From each university's 2026–27 freshman deadline page and the federal and state aid calendars. Some school pages don't print a year, so double-check before you rely on a date.

Date	What's due
Sept 23, 2026	The 2027–28 FAFSA opened (uses 2025 tax information)
Oct 1	FFAA opens (Florida's application for Bright Futures and state aid)
Oct 15	UF Early Decision (binding) · FSU Early Decision and Early Action (EA for Florida residents) · UCF Early Action · FAU Early Action
Oct 22	UF STARS self-reported record due (ED) · FSU and FAU early materials due
Nov 1	UF Early Action (STARS due Nov 8)
Nov 2	USF Early Action · FIU Early Action (FIU: all documents due the same day)
Nov 15–16	UCF early materials due (Nov 15) · USF early materials due (Nov 16)
Dec 1	FSU regular deadline
Dec 4–17	Early decisions arrive: UCF and FAU (Dec 4), USF (Dec 9), FIU (Dec 10), UF ED (Dec 11), FSU (Dec 17)
Dec 16	USF regular deadline · FIU regular deadline
Jan 8, 2027	UF Early Decision admits: confirm and pay the non-refundable \$200 deposit, or the admission is canceled
Jan 15	UF regular deadline (STARS Jan 22) · FSU Early Decision deposit due · USF regular materials and scholarship deadline · FAU merit scholarship deadline
Jan 22	UF Early Action decisions
Feb–Mar	Regular decisions: USF (Feb 10), FSU (Feb 18), UF (Mar 19). Rolling deadlines: FSU and USF (Mar 1), FIU final (Mar 2), FAU (Mar 12)
May 1	UCF regular deadline · Deposit deadline (Early Action and regular admits) at UF, FSU, FIU and FAU
Aug 31, 2027	FFAA final deadline · Last test date that counts for Bright Futures

Early Decision is binding. If admitted Early Decision (UF and FSU both offer it this year), your student commits to attend. Early Action is not binding. When in doubt, choose Early Action.

Month by month

Check off each item as you go. If you're starting late, begin with the current month and use "Key dates" to catch up.

Aug – Sept

set the plan

- ☐ Finalize the college list and each school's plan (ED, EA or regular)
- ☐ If a school wants recommendation letters (UF and UCF don't), ask teachers 3–4 weeks before the deadline
- ☐ Create StudentAid.gov accounts for your student and each parent contributor
- ☐ Draft the main essay and list each school's supplemental essays
- ☐ Register for a fall SAT or ACT if your student needs a higher score

October

early deadlines

- ☐ File the FAFSA (it opened Sept 23) and save the confirmation
- ☐ File the FFAA once it opens Oct 1
- ☐ Submit applications due Oct 15, then complete UF STARS or other self-reported records
- ☐ Ask the counselor for a Bright Futures evaluation
- ☐ Check every portal for missing items

November

keep it moving

- ☐ Submit Nov 1–2 Early Action applications (UF, USF, FIU)
- ☐ Send official test scores to schools that require them
- ☐ Turn in early materials by each school's deadline
- ☐ Retake the SAT or ACT if needed for Bright Futures or admissions

December

decisions start

- ☐ Watch for early decisions (they start Dec 4 at UCF and FAU)
- ☐ Submit regular applications (FSU Dec 1, USF and FIU Dec 16)
- ☐ Apply for at least two scholarships
- ☐ Celebrate every win, and take a breath after any "no"

January

regular round

- ☐ Submit UF's regular application (Jan 15) and STARS (Jan 22)
- ☐ Check scholarship deadlines (USF and FAU merit: Jan 15)
- ☐ Review the FAFSA Submission Summary for errors
- ☐ Send mid-year grades if a school asks for them

Feb – March

finish strong

- ☐ Track regular decisions in the application tracker
- ☐ Make sure service or work hours are documented and turned in (your district sets the deadline)
- ☐ Spring and summer test dates still count for Bright Futures (tests taken through Aug 31)
- ☐ Keep grades up: admission offers can depend on final grades

April

compare + choose

- ☐ Compare aid offers side by side (page 10)
- ☐ Visit admitted-student days at your top choices
- ☐ Ask financial aid offices about anything unclear in an offer
- ☐ Decide as a family

May

commit

- ☐ Pay the deposit by the school's deadline (often May 1)
- ☐ Let the other schools know your student won't be attending
- ☐ Sign up for orientation and housing at the chosen school

June – Aug

last steps

- ☐ Request the final transcript be sent to the chosen school
- ☐ If the FFAA isn't done, submit it by Aug 31, 2027
- ☐ Last Bright Futures test chances: June 5 SAT, June 12 and July 10 ACT, Aug 28 SAT (anticipated). Tests count through Aug 31, 2027

 Test dates for 2026–27

SAT date	Register by	ACT date	Register by
Nov 7, 2026	Oct 23	Oct 17, 2026	Sept 11
Dec 5, 2026	Nov 20	Dec 12, 2026	Nov 6
Mar 6, 2027	Feb 19	Feb 27, 2027	Jan 22
May 1, 2027	Apr 16	Apr 10, 2027	Mar 5
June 5, 2027	May 21	June 12, 2027	May 7
		July 10, 2027	June 4

Bright Futures: *the senior checklist*

Bright Futures is Florida's biggest scholarship. Requirements for the Class of 2027:

	Florida Academic Scholars	Florida Medallion Scholars
Pays	100% of tuition and applicable fees at Florida public colleges and universities	75% of tuition and applicable fees at Florida public universities (100% for an associate degree at a Florida College System school)
Bright Futures GPA	3.50 weighted	3.00 weighted
Test score (one of)	SAT 1330 · ACT 29 · CLT 95	SAT 1190 · ACT 24 · CLT 82
Hours	100 volunteer hours, 100 paid work hours, or a combination totaling 100	75 volunteer hours, 100 paid work hours, or a combination totaling 100

The Bright Futures GPA uses 16 core credits: 4 English, 4 math (Algebra 1 or higher), 3 natural science, 3 social science and 2 credits of the same world language. Honors, AP, IB, AICE and academic dual enrollment courses earn extra weight.

1 This fall

- ☐ Ask the counselor for a Bright Futures evaluation: where does your student stand on GPA, test score and hours?
- ☐ If a score is short, register for the next SAT, ACT or CLT. Students can test as many times as they want
- ☐ Count documented hours. Each one must be signed by your student, a parent and the organization, plus any reflection your district requires

2 Apply: the FFAA

- ☐ Submit the Florida Financial Aid Application (FFAA). It opens Oct 1 of senior year
- ☐ Final deadline: **Aug 31, 2027**, with no exceptions. File it in the fall and save the confirmation

3 Before graduation

- ☐ Turn in all hours by your district's deadline
- ☐ Finish the 16 core credits with the GPA you need (tests taken by Aug 31, 2027 still count)

Not automatic: Even a student who meets every requirement gets nothing without the FFAA. Mid-year graduates have different deadlines; ask the counselor.

FAFSA + FFAA, *step by step*

Two forms, two purposes. Do both in the fall of senior year.

FAFSA (federal)

Opens the door to Pell Grants, work-study, federal loans and many colleges' own aid, plus Florida need-based grants. The 2027–28 FAFSA opened Sept 23, 2026 and uses **2025** tax information.

FFAA (Florida)

Florida's application for Bright Futures and other state scholarships and grants. Opens Oct 1 of senior year. Final deadline Aug 31 after graduation.

1 FAFSA checklist

- ☐ Your student and each parent contributor create a StudentAid.gov account (usually one parent; both if married parents filed taxes separately)
- ☐ Gather your 2025 federal tax return and any untaxed income records
- ☐ Your student starts the FAFSA and invites the parent as a “contributor”
- ☐ Every contributor gives consent to share tax information. Without it, no federal aid
- ☐ List every college your student is applying to
- ☐ Submit, then save the confirmation and review the FAFSA Submission Summary
- ☐ Check each college's financial aid priority date. Many are earlier than you'd expect

2 FFAA checklist

- ☐ Your student completes the FFAA on Florida's student financial aid website
- ☐ Use your student's legal name and Social Security number exactly as the school has them
- ☐ Submit and save the confirmation
- ☐ If your student graduates mid-year, the deadline is Dec 31

3 Also check

- ☐ Does any school on the list require the CSS Profile? (Mostly private colleges.)
- ☐ Does any school require a separate scholarship application?
- ☐ Are there county or local scholarships through your high school?

Application *tracker*

One row per school. Write each deadline one week early: portals get slow on deadline day.

School	Plan (ED/EA/RD)	Deadline	Essays	Self-report (e.g. STARS)	Scores sent	Recs (if required)	Submitted ✓	Decision

Scholarship *tracker*

Apply for a couple every month instead of a pile in spring. Local scholarships often have fewer applicants.

Scholarship	Amount	Deadline	What it needs	Submitted ✓	Result

Where to look: your high school's counseling office, each university's scholarship page, your county's education foundation, employers, churches and community groups.

Compare *aid offers*

Aid letters look different at every school. Put them side by side before paying a deposit.

	School 1	School 2	School 3
Cost of attendance (tuition, fees, housing, food, books)			
Bright Futures			
Grants (free money)			
Scholarships (free money)			
Total free money			
Cost minus free money			
Loans offered			
Work-study			
What we would actually pay per year			

? Questions to ask each financial aid office

- ☐ Is this aid renewable every year? What GPA or credits does it require?
- ☐ How does Bright Futures combine with your scholarships?
- ☐ Will this offer change if we have new information (like a job change)?
- ☐ When is the deposit due, and is it refundable?

This roadmap is for planning help only and isn't official advice. Requirements and dates can change; confirm with your school counselor, each university and [FloridaBrightFutures.gov](https://floridabrightfutures.gov). College Plan is not affiliated with the State of Florida or any university. © 2026 College Plan.